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When to Stop Trusting a System You Built

No system delivers infinite efficiency, and stopping one you built and are responsible for isn't a decision to make lightly. On what "stopping" actually means when a system only flags rather than acts.

The check that actually works isn't trusting your own read on whether it's still net positive — it's the same principle the system was built around: don't let the person closest to the decision be the only one making it.

No system delivers infinite efficiency, and it was never supposed to. The point of the behavioral risk framework I built wasn't to replace judgment, it was to make human judgment faster to apply, to save time that would otherwise go into reading every message from scratch. Even when the system ran on its own, generating flags automatically, the final call always stayed with a person. That single design choice, keeping the decision human no matter how automated the detection got, was what gave anyone real control over what the system actually did.

That distinction matters more than it sounds like it should, because it changes what "stopping" a system even means. A system that only flags, and never acts on its own, doesn't need an emergency kill switch in the way a fully automated one would. The stakes of it running with a bug or a bad pattern are lower, because nothing happens without a human reading the case first. What you're actually deciding, when you ask whether to keep using something like this, isn't "is this dangerous right now," it's "is this still worth the maintenance and oversight it requires."

That's a different question, and it has a different bar. Stopping something you built and are responsible for isn't a decision you make lightly, and it shouldn't be. If a system is doing more good than harm, overall, across the volume of cases it's actually helping with, the imperfections don't automatically disqualify it. No detection system is going to be flawless. Some false positives, some missed cases, some patterns it wasn't built to catch, that's the baseline cost of using pattern-based detection at all, not a sign that the whole thing has failed.

The harder part isn't building that tolerance for imperfection. It's being honest with yourself about where the line actually sits, because you're evaluating something you made, and that comes with its own kind of blind spot. I built this system. That fact doesn't make me more objective about when it's failing, if anything it makes it harder, because every flaw I find is also a flaw in something I designed. The check that actually works isn't trusting your own read on whether it's still net positive. It's the same principle the system itself was built around: don't let the person closest to the decision

be the only one making it. A system that flags instead of acting, and routes every real call to a human, isn’t just a safeguard for the players it’s protecting. It’s a safeguard against the builder’s own certainty that everything is still working the way they think it is.

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